Spirits of the Wild — Player Manual

A game for 2 players · Mattel · Game design by Nick Hayes

This is an unofficial, plain-language player manual. It explains the complete rules in our own words, adds a quick FAQ, and closes with some beginner strategy tips. Where the printed rules are silent or differ between editions, this manual says so clearly.

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1. The Story

Long ago, five animals of the forest — Rabbit, Turtle, Salmon, Owl and Beaver — rose up into the night sky and became stars. In time they came back to the earth as spirits. Each spirit has its own taste in precious stones, and whoever brings them the gifts they love best will earn their favour.

But not everyone in the forest is pleased. The Coyote is jealous of the spirits' attention, and wherever he sits down, no gifts can be given.

You and your opponent are rival gatherers. Collect stones, offer them to your animal spirits, and keep the Coyote off your back.

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2. Object of the Game

On your turn you play one of your **action cards** to collect stones. Every stone you collect is placed on one of the **five animals** on your player board, as long as it fits that animal's requirement. Each animal scores points for the sets you build. When the game ends, the player with the **most points wins**.

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3. Components

Item	Quantity
Bowl	1
Cloth bag	1
Coyote pawn	1
Player boards	2
Action cards	12 (6 per player)
Spirit Power cards	6
Stones	56 (8 in each of 7 colours)

The stones: there are six *regular* colours — **green, yellow, blue, purple, white and red** — plus **clear (opalescent) stones**, called **Spirit Stones**. Spirit Stones are special: they are *not* a seventh regular colour and follow their own rules (see section 7).

Each player's six action cards:

1. Take One Stone
2. Take One Stone (a second copy)
3. Take Two Stones
4. Add Two Stones & Take One
5. Add Three Stones & Move Coyote
6. Use Spirit Power & Recover Cards

The six Spirit Power cards: Bear, Wolf, Ram, Eagle, Deer and Bison.

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4. Setup

1. **Table layout.** Put the bowl between the two players. Set the Coyote pawn off to one side for now.
2. **Fill the bag.** Put all 56 stones in the cloth bag and shake it well.
3. **Seed the bowl.** Draw 4 stones from the bag into the bowl. If any of them are Spirit Stones, put those back in the bag and draw replacements. Keep doing this until the bowl holds **4 regular (non-Spirit) stones**.
4. **Player areas.** Each player takes a player board and lays their 6 action cards **face-up** in front of it.
5. **Spirit Power cards.** Shuffle the 6 Spirit Power cards and split them into **two face-up piles of 3 cards** each. Place both piles where both players can see them. Only the top card of each pile is available at any time.
6. **First player.** Decide who starts in any way you like. The **start player flips their "Take Two Stones" card face-down** — it is unavailable to them until they recover their cards. (This offsets the advantage of going first.)

You are ready to play.

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5. Playing a Turn

Players alternate turns. On your turn:

1. **Choose one of your face-up action cards.**
2. **Carry out its action** completely.
3. **Turn that card face-down.** A face-down card cannot be used again until you recover your cards (with *Use Spirit Power & Recover Cards*).

Then your opponent takes their turn.

Availability rule: you may only choose a card if you can actually do what it says. In particular, if the card tells you to *take* stones from the bowl, those stones must be there. For example, you can't play *Take Two Stones* when the bowl holds only one stone.

Every stone you take is immediately placed on your player board (see section 6). If it doesn't fit anywhere, it goes back to the bowl.

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6. The Action Cards in Detail

Take One Stone (you have two of these)

Take **1 stone** of your choice from the bowl and place it on your board. *Can't be played if the bowl is empty.*

The back of each *Take One Stone* card shows **half of a Coyote**. See section 9 for why that matters.

Take Two Stones

Take **2 stones** of your choice from the bowl and place them on your board. *Can't be played if the bowl holds fewer than 2 stones.*

Add Two Stones & Take One

Draw **2 stones** from the bag (without looking) and put them in the bowl. Then take **1 stone** of your choice from the bowl and place it on your board.

Add Three Stones & Move Coyote

Draw **3 stones** from the bag into the bowl. Then you **may** place the Coyote on any one animal on your **opponent's** board. (You don't take a stone with this card.)

Use Spirit Power & Recover Cards

*Only playable if at least **three of your other five** action cards are face-down.*

1. Choose **one** of the two face-up Spirit Power cards (the top card of either pile).
2. Carry out its instructions **in the order written** (see section 8).
3. Move that Spirit Power card to the **bottom of its own pile**, revealing a new top card.
4. **Turn all six of your action cards face-up** again — including this one.

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7. Placing Stones on Your Board

Your board shows five animals. Each animal has its own section of spaces and its own **requirement** for which stones it accepts.

- A stone may only be placed in a section if it **meets that animal's requirement**.
- If you take a stone that can't legally go **anywhere** on your board, **return it to the bowl**.
- Stones stay where you place them (except when the Deer power lets you move one back to the bowl).

The five animals

Rabbit — three different colours

Fill the Rabbit with **3 stones, all of different colours**. **Scores 6 points**, but **only** once all 3 are in place. An incomplete Rabbit scores nothing.

Turtle — all one colour

Every stone on the Turtle must be **the same colour**. Score depends on how many stones you have there:

Stones	1	2	3	4	5
Points	1	3	6	9	14

Salmon — all different colours

Every stone on the Salmon must be a **different colour** (one of each). Score depends on the number of stones:

Stones	1	2	3	4	5	6
Points	1	2	4	6	9	13

Owl — matching pairs

The Owl collects **pairs of the same colour**. Each **completed pair scores 4 points**.

- You don't have to finish a pair in one turn.
- You may start a new pair before finishing an earlier one.
- Only **complete** pairs score; a lone half-pair is worth nothing.

> **Edition note:** The German 2019 rulesheet values each Owl pair at **4 points**. The English 2017 Mattel rulebook (FWK82) gives **3 points** per pair. This manual uses 4 as the standard value. If your board or rulebook says 3, agree before the game which value you use.

Beaver — three-of-a-kind plus a pair

The Beaver wants two sets:

- a **three-of-a-kind** (3 stones of one colour) — **5 points**, and
- a **pair** (2 stones of one colour) — **2 points**.

If you complete **both** sets, you get a **7-point bonus**, for a **total of 14 points**. You may work on either set first, and you don't need to complete either in a single turn. Only completed sets score.

Spirit Stones (clear)

Spirit Stones are powerful but restricted:

- A Spirit Stone may **only** be placed in the **bonus space** next to an animal's picture — never in the regular spaces.

- It **doubles** that animal's points at the end of the game.
- Placing it **closes** that animal's section: **no more stones** of any kind may be added there afterwards.
- A Spirit Stone is **not** one of the six regular colours. It never counts toward a colour requirement.

Because a Spirit Stone locks the section, the best moment to place it is usually when that animal is already full or close to its best value.

If you take a Spirit Stone and have no open bonus space to put it in (for example, all your animals are closed or under the Coyote), it goes back to the bowl like any other stone that cannot be placed.

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8. The Spirit Power Cards

When you use *Use Spirit Power & Recover Cards*, choose one of the two face-up Spirit Power cards and resolve it step by step:

Spirit	What it does
Bear	Count the stones in the bowl. Put them all back in the bag. Draw the **same number** of stones from the bag into the bowl. Then take **1 stone** from the bowl and place it on your board.
Wolf	Draw **4 stones** from the bag into the bowl. Then take **1 stone** from the bowl and place it on your board.
Ram	Draw **2 stones** from the bag and place them **directly on your board**. You must place both if you legally can. Any you can't place go into the bowl.
Eagle	Take **1 stone** from the bowl and place it on your board. After you recover your action cards, **take another turn** immediately.
Deer	Move **1 stone** from your own board back to the bowl. Then take **2 stones** from the bowl and place them on your board.
Bison	Draw **3 stones** from the bag into the bowl. Take **1 stone** from the bowl and place it on your board. Then take **another stone** from the bowl and **return it to the bag**. (Neither stone has to be one of the three you just drew.)

After resolving it, slide the used card to the bottom of its pile, then turn all six of your action cards face-up.

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9. The Coyote

The Coyote is a nuisance you place on your opponent's board.

Effect: while the Coyote sits on one of your animals, you **cannot add any stones** to that animal's section — not even a Spirit Stone. Stones already there stay and still score normally. The block lasts until the Coyote moves somewhere else.

There are two ways to move the Coyote onto your opponent's board:

1. **Add Three Stones & Move Coyote** — after drawing the 3 stones, you *may* place the Coyote on one of your opponent's animals.
2. **The Coyote picture** — each of your two *Take One Stone* cards shows half a Coyote on its back. When **both** of them are face-down, the two halves form a complete Coyote, and you may move the Coyote to any animal on your opponent's board.

The Coyote can only ever be on one animal at a time. Moving it to your opponent's board automatically frees whichever animal it was on before.

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10. End of the Game

Check at the **end of every turn**: if **five Spirit Stones are out of the bag** — counting those in the bowl and on both players' boards together — the game **ends immediately**.

The Bison power can send a Spirit Stone back to the bag. If that brings the number of Spirit Stones outside the bag below five **before the turn ends**, the game does **not** end and play continues.

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11. Scoring

Each player adds up the points of their five animals:

- **Rabbit:** 6 if complete, otherwise 0.
- **Turtle:** by number of same-coloured stones (1 / 3 / 6 / 9 / 14).
- **Salmon:** by number of different-coloured stones (1 / 2 / 4 / 6 / 9 / 13).
- **Owl:** 4 points per completed pair (3 in the English 2017 edition).
- **Beaver:** 5 for the three-of-a-kind, 2 for the pair, plus 7 bonus if both are complete (14 total).

Then **double** the points of every animal that has a Spirit Stone in its bonus space.

The player with the higher total wins.

Tie-breaker: if the totals are equal, the player who **currently has the Coyote on their board** wins. (The spirits take pity on the one the Coyote has been bothering.)

Scoring example

Mia finishes with:

- Rabbit complete → 6
- Turtle with 4 blue stones and a Spirit Stone → 9 × 2 = 18
- Salmon with 3 different colours → 4
- Owl with 2 completed pairs and one single stone → 8
- Beaver with the three-of-a-kind only → 5

Total: 6 + 18 + 4 + 8 + 5 = **41 points**.

12. FAQ / Clarifications

How many spaces does each animal have? The rules don't state the exact number of spaces per section. The scoring implies Rabbit 3, Turtle up to 5, Salmon up to 6 and Beaver 5 (3 + 2). The number of Owl spaces depends on what is printed on your board — use the spaces shown. In all cases, follow your physical board.

What if the bag runs out of stones? The rules don't cover this. *Suggested house rule:* draw as many stones as are left and carry out the rest of the action as far as possible. If the bag is completely empty, a "draw" step simply does nothing.

Can I play a card if part of it can't be done? You must be able to take any stones the card requires from the bowl. Steps that *add* stones to the bowl from the bag (and the optional Coyote move) don't block a card. If you take a stone you can't place, it goes back to the bowl — that is still a legal play.

Do Spirit Stones count as a colour for the Salmon, Rabbit or anything else? No. They only ever go in a bonus space, and they are not one of the six regular colours.

Can I place a Spirit Stone on an empty animal? The rules only require that it goes into a bonus space; nothing forbids an empty animal. But it closes the section, and double zero is still zero — so it's almost never a good idea.

Can the Coyote block a section with a Spirit Stone already in it? Yes, you may place it there, but it has no effect — that section is already closed. It's normally a wasted move.

Can I put the Coyote on my own board? No. You always move it onto an animal on your **opponent's** board.

What happens to the Coyote at the start of the game? It starts beside the play area and blocks nobody until someone moves it onto the opponent's board.

When exactly does the Take One Stone Coyote picture trigger? When the second of your two *Take One Stone* cards is turned face-down, both halves show and you may move the Coyote. The card play itself (taking one stone) happens first. Since recovering your cards flips them face-up again, you can trigger this once per "cycle" of your cards.

I used the Eagle. Do I get my cards back before the extra turn? Yes. You take your stone, recover all six cards, and then take your extra turn with a full hand of face-up cards.

With the Ram, can I put a drawn Spirit Stone on my board? Yes, if you have an open bonus space. Ram says you must place both stones if possible — so a placeable Spirit Stone must be placed. Anything you cannot place goes to the bowl.

With the Deer, can I remove a Spirit Stone or a stone from a Coyote-blocked animal? The rules don't restrict which of your stones you remove. Note that removing a stone may break a set (for example, an Owl pair). Agree on a ruling before play if this matters to you. *Suggested house rule:* any stone on your board may be removed, but you can't then add stones to a closed or Coyote-blocked section.

Does the game end the instant the fifth Spirit Stone appears? The check happens at the **end of the turn**. So you finish your turn first — which matters for the Bison, which can return a Spirit Stone to the bag.

What if the Coyote was never used — who wins a tie? The rules give no fallback. *Suggested house rule:* share the victory.

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13. Strategy Tips for Beginners

These are our own suggestions, not rules.

- **Watch the Spirit Stones.** Count how many are out of the bag. Once three or four are out, every draw from the bag could end the game — make sure your board is in a scoring state.
- **Turtle and Salmon grow fast at the top.** The last stone is worth the most (Turtle 9 → 14, Salmon 9 → 13). A Spirit Stone on a full Turtle (28) or full Salmon (26) is a game-winner.
- **Don't close a section too early.** A Spirit Stone locks the section. Place it once the animal is full or nearly full — unless the game is about to end.
- **Finish what you start.** Rabbit, Owl pairs and Beaver sets score nothing when incomplete. Avoid having too many half-finished sets near the end.
- **Use the Coyote on your opponent's best open animal** — usually a Turtle or Salmon that is one or two stones away from a big jump. Don't waste it on a section that's already closed.
- **Plan your recovery.** You need three face-down cards before you can use a Spirit Power. Look at the two face-up Spirit Powers and time your recovery for the one that helps you most (Eagle's extra turn and Deer's two stones are strong).
- **Mind what you leave in the bowl.** Adding stones to the bowl also helps your opponent. Before you play *Add Two* or *Add Three*, think about what colours they need.
- **Bison is a defensive tool.** It can pull a Spirit Stone back into the bag — handy to delay the end when you're behind, or to deny your opponent a Spirit Stone.
- **Keep the tie-breaker in mind.** In a close game, having the Coyote on *your* board wins ties — so moving it onto your opponent late in the game can backfire.

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